

THE **AI** REPORT

THE AI RESEARCH SYSTEM: **A THREE-PHASE** **METHOD**

for Getting Better Research Done Faster



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Trusted by 400,000+ business leaders

3 years covering AI hiring and adoption daily

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INTRODUCTION

HERE IS THE THING ABOUT AI RESEARCH THAT NOBODY TELLS YOU.

THE OUTPUT QUALITY IS NOT DETERMINED BY WHICH MODEL YOU USE. IT IS DETERMINED BY WHETHER YOU HAVE A PROCESS AT ALL.

- Right now, most professionals open ChatGPT, type a question, accept the first confident-sounding answer, and move on.
- The problem is that AI models are confident whether they are right or wrong.
- An answer that sounds authoritative can be wrong, outdated, or fabricated.
- Using one model as your only source is using a single, fallible voice as your entire evidence base.

There is a better way. It is not about using more tools or asking better questions. It is about running research as a three-phase process, where each phase uses a different tool for a different job.

This guide gives you that process.

READING THIS FROM THE FREE COMMUNITY? LEADERS LAUNCH MEMBERS GET THE FULL IMPLEMENTATION SYSTEM:

16 lessons, HubSpot AI playbooks, an AI tools quick-start, 5 custom GPTs, and more added continuously.

Unlock the AI Report leaders launch Guide

<https://www.theaireport.ai/leaders-launch-guide>

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

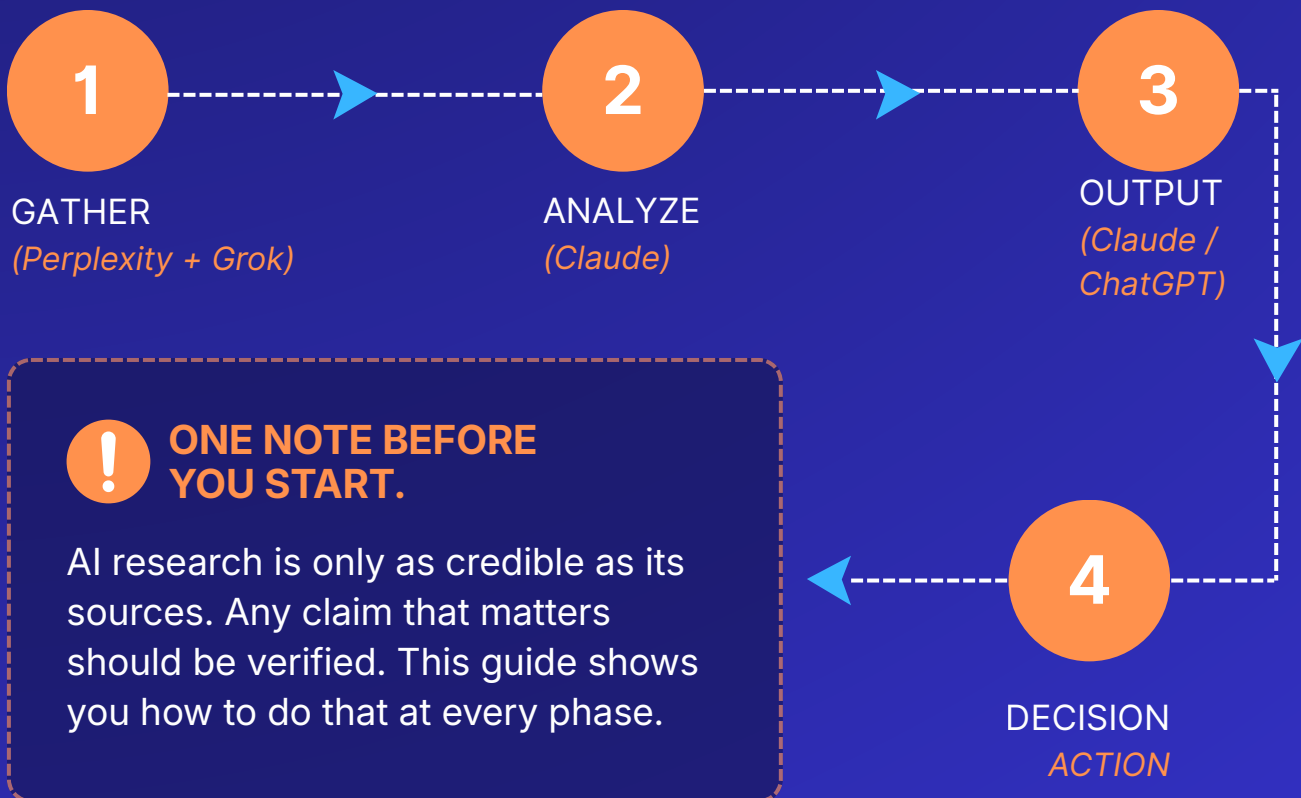
Run The Research Process In Order

Phase one gathers your raw material,

phase two turns it into insight,

and phase three produces the deliverable.

Don't skip phase one and jump straight to analysis. The quality of your output is determined almost entirely by the quality of what you feed into phase two.



PHASE 1

GATHER



TOOL: PERPLEXITY

Perplexity is search-first and always cites sources.

Every answer it produces links to the original source material. That citation habit is what makes it the right tool for phase one. You're not looking for AI opinion. You are looking for sourced, traceable starting material.

Start every research session here.

What to use Perplexity for:

Source discovery. Web research. Market data. Current events. Regulatory updates. Competitor news. Any question where you need a sourced answer rather than a generated one.

How to prompt Perplexity for better research:

Don't ask general questions. Ask specific ones.

Instead of: "What are the trends in AI hiring?"

Ask: "What do 2026 employer surveys report about AI skill requirements in job postings? Cite sources."

Instead of: "Tell me about competitor X."

Ask: "What has competitor X announced in the last 90 days? What do their recent job postings suggest about their strategic direction? Cite all sources."

The more specific the question, the more useful the sourced answer.



TOOL: GROK

What Grok adds to phase one:

For anything where real-time intelligence matters, add Grok. **Grok is connected directly to X data in real-time.** News breaks there before it reaches any newsletter. If you're tracking a fast-moving market, a competitor's announcement, or a regulatory development, Grok surfaces what Perplexity may not yet have indexed. Use Perplexity for structured, sourced research. Use Grok when you need to know what's happening right now.

Phase one output: A set of sourced notes, links, and data points. Not polished. Not synthesized. Just raw material you can verify and hand to phase two.

PHASE 2

ANALYZE



TOOL: CLAUDE

Claude is built for long-form thinking. It reads large amounts of material, identifies patterns, synthesizes across sources, and extracts what matters. This is where your phase one material becomes insight.

What to use Claude for:

Summarizing findings. Identifying patterns. Synthesizing across multiple sources. Extracting key points. Generating strategic takeaways. Pressure-testing your interpretation.

The analysis prompts:

Use these from The AI Report's Executive Prompt Library. All are copy-paste ready.

Prompt #84: Research Synthesis

Use after every phase one gathering session.

I have gathered the following research on [topic]. Synthesize it into a briefing of no more than one page covering: the three most important findings, what these findings mean for our business specifically, the key areas of uncertainty or conflicting evidence, and the one or two questions that still need to be answered before we can act with confidence.

Research: [paste in your phase one notes]

PRO TIP FROM THE EXECUTIVE PROMPT LIBRARY:

"Ask: 'For each finding, tell me how confident we should be in it and what the source quality is.' Research synthesis is most valuable when it separates what is known from what is assumed."

Prompt #85: Competitive Intelligence Brief

Use when phase one focuses on a specific competitor.

Build me a competitive intelligence brief on [competitor]. Based on the following sources and what you know, cover: their current product positioning and how it has changed recently, pricing strategy and packaging, go-to-market approach and primary channels, known strengths and vulnerabilities, recent signals about their strategic direction, and one or two things they are likely to do next.

Sources: [paste in your phase one notes]

PRO TIP FROM THE EXECUTIVE PROMPT LIBRARY:

"Ask: 'For each finding, tell me how confident we should be in it and what the source quality is.' Research synthesis is most valuable when it separates what is known from what is assumed."

Prompt #86: Industry Trend Analysis

Use when phase one covers a market shift or emerging pattern.

Analyze the following trends affecting [your industry]: [list what you found]. For each trend: how material it is likely to be in the next two to three years, whether it represents a threat or an opportunity for our business specifically, what leading companies in our space are doing in response, and what we should be doing now to either capitalize on or protect against it.

PRO TIP FROM THE EXECUTIVE PROMPT LIBRARY:

"Ask: 'Of these trends, which one requires a decision from us in the next 90 days?' Trend analysis is only useful if it leads to action."

THE THREE MISTAKES MOST PEOPLE MAKE IN PHASE TWO:

MISTAKE 1:

TRUSTING FIRST OUTPUTS.

The first synthesis is a starting point, not a conclusion. Ask Claude to identify the weakest assumption in its own analysis. The follow-up almost always produces something more valuable than the initial response.

MISTAKE 2:

WEAK PROMPTING.

Generic input produces generic output. The prompts above include specific output requirements, number of findings, format, confidence levels. That specificity is what separates useful synthesis from a summary you would have written yourself.

MISTAKE 3:

SHALLOW SOURCING.

If phase one did not produce real sources, phase two cannot fix that. The quality of analysis is directly proportional to the quality of the inputs.

HOW TO VERIFY WHAT PHASE TWO PRODUCES:

- Before any research finding becomes a claim you act on or share, verify it.
- The AI Report covered this directly: cross-verify significant claims across two or more models.
- If Claude synthesizes a key finding, paste the same underlying data into a second model and compare.
- Agreement across models is not proof of accuracy, but disagreement is a signal to dig further.
- For factual claims, go back to the original sourced links from phase one.
- Verify the claim in the primary source.
- Never share AI-produced research with a senior stakeholder without having traced at least the key facts to a named, verifiable source.

PHASE 3

OUTPUT

Phase three turns your synthesized insight into a deliverable someone else can use. The tool choice depends on the format.



TOOL:
CLAUDE

reports, memos, strategy documents, written briefs, anything requiring voice and judgment.



TOOL:
CHATGPT

structured formats, content where pattern and completeness matter more than prose quality, data-heavy summaries.

THE OUTPUT PROMPT:

Use this from the Executive Prompt Library across any deliverable type.

Prompt #91: Data Story Narrative

I have the following research that I need to present to [audience, leadership, board, client, team]: [describe or paste in your phase two synthesis]. Help me turn this into a narrative that: opens with the single most important finding, builds the supporting evidence in a logical sequence, explains what the data means for our strategy or decisions, and closes with a clear recommendation or call to action.
The audience cares most about: [describe what matters to them]

PRO TIP FROM THE EXECUTIVE PROMPT LIBRARY:

Use this from the Executive Prompt Library across any deliverable type.

Phase three output formats:

- The same phase two synthesis can produce different outputs for different audiences. The research does not change. The framing does.
- **For a CEO:** three findings and one recommendation. For a board: risk context and financial implications. **For a client:** how it affects them specifically. **For a team:** what it means for how they work next week.
- Tell the model who it is writing for and what that person cares most about. The output adjusts accordingly.

THE SYSTEM IN PRACTICE

USE CASE 1:

COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

Phase one: **GATHER**

- Perplexity search on top five competitors.
- Grok scan for recent announcements and hiring patterns.
- Collect sourced notes.

Phase two: **ANALYZE**

- Claude with Prompt #85 for each competitor.
- Prompt #86 for sector-wide trend read.

Phase three: **OUTPUT**

- Prompt #91 into a one-page competitive brief for the leadership team.

USE CASE 2:

MARKET RESEARCH

Phase one: **GATHER**

- Perplexity for market data, industry reports, customer signals.
- Grok for recent news.

Phase two: **ANALYZE**

- Claude with Prompt #84 for synthesis.
- Prompt #86 for trend analysis.

Phase three: **OUTPUT**

- Prompt #91 into a market briefing document.
- Or export to slides using Gamma.

USE CASE 3:

PRE-MEETING RESEARCH

Phase one: **GATHER**

- Perplexity on the company, person, or topic you are meeting about.

Phase two: **ANALYZE**

- Claude with Prompt #84 to synthesize the key context.

Phase three: **OUTPUT**

- A short briefing note using Prompt #91, three findings, one question to open with.

WHAT THIS CHANGES

- Most people finish research wishing they had more time.
- This system does not give you more time. It gives you better output in the time you already spend.
- The gathering is more targeted, the analysis is more structured, and the output is more useful.
- That's what changes when you treat research as a three-phase process instead of a single question typed into a chat window.

THE NATURAL NEXT STEP

The ROI framework tells you what is working.

The AI Leaders Launch Guide builds the implementation system that makes sure it keeps working across your whole organisation.



16 lessons



HubSpot AI playbooks



AI tools quick-start



3 custom GPTs



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